

KAREN HEADOUT EDIT

Travel Radio Australia, and we're here at the Great Arrival 360 conference. It's a professional travel conference in Brisbane, Australia, and I'm here with Karen Larson from HeadOut. Now, HeadOut is a fantastic company where you can go there and get all sorts of experiences around travel from the whole world.

Karen, welcome to the program. Thank you so much. Thank you so much.

Now, Karen, tell us about HeadOut. How does it basically work? It's a real fantastic hub for people wanting to find information. Yeah, that's absolutely right.

So we're an OTA, a marketplace where anyone can go to find incredible experiences anywhere in the world. So that could be New Zealand, Fiji, it could be Hanoi, Japan, London, you name it, we're there. Now, those experiences mean so many different things to so many different people.

For example, say I'm flying into Sydney. I'm going to book a show on the harbour, on the water, beautiful view. And you can do that directly on HeadOut through seat map functionality.

Then maybe the next day, I'm going to go to Taronga Zoo, and then maybe do a food tour around the rocks, go see the history as well and explore that. So experiences to us mean many different things. We work mostly directly with our partners.

So our partners to sign up directly on HeadOut. We connect via a number of different API providers. So straight off the bat, in Australia, that looks like RISD.

I think we've all heard of RISD, Fiyahaba, Custom Link, RISPax, Ventrata, Boken, Overseas. Companies can also work with us on a free sale model. As we know, not everyone has API capability.

Some people are on requests, so we can absolutely accommodate that. In Australia, it's not too prominent, but as you can imagine, in a lot of these smaller Asian cities, where they're just starting to open up distribution, that's where it's really important as well. Now, you were telling me about the origins of HeadOut.

And can you just give us the website so people know where it is? Yeah, absolutely. So that's www.headout.com. So my Kiwi accent, I'll just spell that out. So that's H-E-A-D-O-U-T.

And you were telling me that it all started from the Lion King. Tell us about that. Absolutely.

So it started over 10 years ago, and the first ever ticket experience sold on HeadOut was the Lion King in New York, and it soon expanded from there. I guess you could say our mature markets are the US and Europe. And in the last, say, five to six years, we really ramped up our efforts in ANZ.

I'm based in Sydney, and then we have my colleague Nathan, who's based in New Zealand, and we're managing the Australia market. The thing is, people can go to HeadOut.com, and they can choose experiences, as you said before, and they can do a whole itinerary through you guys. Yeah, absolutely.

They can find anything they want along their trip to Australia. Say, I want to start in Cairns, fly directly from Singapore. We know there's some direct flights.

I'm going to do snorkeling. I'm going to go to Karanda, tick off those bucket lists. But then you can also do those smaller experiences, the ones that, more often than not, that you do remember, because maybe you're meeting a local, you're understanding a little bit of the background.

So you can definitely do your full itinerary on HeadOut. And the whole concept, as the name suggests, is to head out. Head outside, get off your couch, get off Netflix, get off YouTube, but head outside and enjoy your backyard, or travel somewhere new.

And again, it could be your backyard where you can find incredible experiences listed under Head Out. So we are OTA, as I mentioned, a place for customers to discover, and customers these days are discovering experiences in an app, in an app-based format. Yeah.

Karen Larson from HeadOut.com. Now, you must get to try out a lot of these experiences. Can you tell me about some of your standout experiences you've had recently? Well, that's actually a really good question, because I just flew back from India yesterday. Really? What part of India were you? So I went to Bangalore.

So HeadOut's HQ, I like to say HeadOut's heartbeat is in India, Bangalore. So we have about 500 to 700 people in India. Our three founders are from India originally.

So they're based there. A whole bunch of our awesome team are based there. I was just in India for a week, and there's one direct flight from Sydney, as most people know from Bangalore.

So I was flying out at 6pm on Saturday, and I had some time before my flight, and I was like, like any customer, what's there to do in Bangalore? And so I did an experience which was called Off the Beaten Tracks Walking Tour with Bangalore Guide. So obviously that appealed to me. I'm an experienced traveler.

I want to go off the beaten tracks. I want to see maybe those alleyways of the city. And that's definitely what I did.

So definitely a memorable experience. We saw some murals that really helped me understand the history of Bangalore and why those murals were there. We tried some food, we went to the park, we went to some temples, again, learning a little bit more about the culture.

But that's my most recent experience, which was only a day ago, and that was in India. Now I'm

in Brisbane. So going from country to country to country.

One other special thing you've done in the past few years? Past few years, probably plus plus onto that. And now I didn't book this one on OTA, but I think this really served before Janelle was kind of guiding everyone at the Welcome Talk at arrival about how she came into tourism. And she came into tourism because she had awesome experience in Australia.

And I think we're all here for a reason that connects us, and that's we love travel. So one memory that sticks deep in my mind was when I did Annapurna Base Camp in Nepal. So just so incredible.

The memories you make, the people you see, my guide was awesome. And yeah, that will always hold a special place in my heart. And I think that kind of solidified.

I was working in tourism at the time, but in hotels. And that really solidified for me. I love hotels, love tourism, but let's go to the fun side and the fun side experiences for sure.

Well, Karen Larson from headout.com. It's been fantastic having you on the program, and thank you very much for joining us. And can you, are you from New Zealand? What part of New Zealand are you from? I'm from Whanganui. Yeah.

Great. Yeah. And tell us a little bit about that before we go.

I've been in Sydney. So I live actually currently in Sydney and I've been in Sydney for about 10 years. And yeah, have a little toddler at home.

I mean, 17 months keeps him busy. But yeah, now I call Sydney home for sure. Well, thanks very much for being on the program and you can head out to headout.com. Everyone must say that.

A bit of a catchphrase for you. I know, I know. It's a good play on words, isn't it? Thanks for being with us on Travel Radio Australia, Karen.

Yeah. Thank you. Thanks.